GIANT DROP

Game Design Document

Working Title: Giant Drop

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Developer: Allison (Solo)

Target Engine: Unity

This document consolidates the answers gathered during design interview sessions. Sections marked "Design note (draft — please review)" are proposals filling gaps that weren't explicitly specified — confirm, edit, or replace them before implementation begins.

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Revision history — v1.0 (this revision): Section 9.1 locks the visual style as heavy cel-shading with thick ink outlines and a comic-book look (ref. Mecha Legends demo trailer / Hellboy), replacing the plain low-poly description; flags a new open question in Section 13 about shader R&D and asset-pipeline impact. v0.9: Section 3 adds a concept art reference image illustrating the fantasy-creature-plus-sci-fi-technology fusion described in the setting text (fantasy giant fitted with a technological exoskeleton and pilot rig). v0.8: Section 5.4 confirms the Giant call-in cooldown rule — the cooldown/kill-reduction meter for the next Giant does not start until the currently active Giant is destroyed (previously marked "to be confirmed"). v0.7: Section 5.1 now scopes the overworld map selection as a simple list for now, not an explorable overworld visual, with a Ball x Pit reference screenshot added as Section 14.1. v0.6: added a PlateUp! reference screenshot to Section 14.1, specifically illustrating manual-vs-automated stations, and cross-linked it from Section 6.2. v0.5: added a core-loop diagram (Figure 1) to Section 4, illustrating the Phase 1 / Phase 2 cycle. v0.4: Section 14 now embeds actual reference screenshots (captured live from each game's official Steam store page) instead of link-only references. v0.3: added Section 14, Visual References. v0.2: restructured the core loop into two named phases modeled on Cult of the Lamb (Phase 1: Home Base, Phase 2: Overworld Run). Base building is now built around automation machines rather than generic structures. The Giant system is now boss-based — defeating a map's boss permanently unlocks that boss as a controllable Giant, building a roster over time. Overworld runs now culminate in a mandatory boss fight once the survival timer expires. See Sections 4, 5, 6, and 7 for the updated systems, and Section 13 for what's still open.

1. High-Concept Pitch

Giant Drop is a solo-developed, mature-toned PC game for Steam that fuses Vampire Survivors-style swarm combat with a Cult of the Lamb-style two-phase loop: a home base you build up between expeditions, and an overworld map you venture into to fight for it. Instead of tending followers, the player automates their base with machines that generate the resources needed to make their character — and eventually their Giants — stronger. Out on the overworld, each map ends in a boss fight; defeating a boss doesn't just end the run, it permanently adds that boss to the player's roster as a controllable Giant — a massive war machine/creature (a nod to Titanfall's titan drop) that the player can call in and fully pilot, replacing their human character, once they've earned it again in a later run.

One sentence pitch: "Build your base, survive the overworld, and defeat bosses to add them to your arsenal as Giants."

2. Game Overview

2.1 Genre

Survival-action / bullet-heaven hybrid with base-building and colony-management elements. Closest reference points: Vampire Survivors (swarm combat, auto-attack power fantasy), a grid-based base builder (structure placement and permanent upgrades), and Titanfall (the giant/titan call-in and pilot moment).

2.2 Platform

PC, targeting Steam.

2.3 Target Audience & Tone

Mature / hardcore players who enjoy roguelite-adjacent survival games, deckbuilders, and base builders — players who want run-based tension paired with the long-term satisfaction of watching a base grow. Tone is darker and more intense than a "casual" bullet-heaven game: higher stakes framing, tougher difficulty curve, sci-fi-meets-fantasy horror-tinged visuals.

2.4 Team & Scope

Solo developer. Every system in this document is scoped with that constraint in mind: reused mechanics over bespoke one-offs, a single playable character for the first release, placeholder art during systems development,

and a base-building layer that is deliberately simple (grid placement, no crew/citizen simulation, no crafting subsystem) so it can be built and balanced by one person.

2.5 Engine

Unity (LTS version to be pinned in the Technical Overview, Section 10).

3. Setting & Theme

Giant Drop takes place in a sci-fi setting populated by fantasy-flavored creatures — the world and framing (technology, factions, locations) are science-fiction, but the enemies the player fights are demons, beasts, and other mythic monsters reskinned into that sci-fi frame rather than robots or aliens in the traditional sense.

Design note (draft — please review): The specific fiction is still open: what sci-fi setting (deep space colony, ruined future-Earth, a fallen research facility, etc.) and why fantasy creatures exist within it (a dimensional rift, an experiment gone wrong, an ancient force awakened by technology) are not yet defined. Section 13 flags this as a priority open question, since it will shape enemy design, base theming, and the Giant's visual identity.

Each boss — and by extension each Giant the player unlocks by defeating it — should read as a collision point of both halves of the setting: a creature or war machine empowered or corrupted by whatever fantasy force is loose in this sci-fi world. Their exact nature (piloted mechs infused with magic, technologically-bound monsters, ancient guardians retrofitted with tech, or a mix across the roster) is part of the same open question above, and will double as the visual throughline that makes the growing Giant roster feel like one coherent bestiary rather than a grab-bag.



Concept reference — a fantasy giant (aged, mythic, hand-and-knees scale against the landscape) fitted with a technological exoskeleton and a pilot's control rig on its back, complete with holographic displays. This is the target fusion for the setting: fantasy creature design read through a sci-fi technology layer, rather than a robot or a wizard on their own. Source: AI-generated concept art commissioned for this document.

4. Core Gameplay Loop

Giant Drop follows a two-phase loop modeled on Cult of the Lamb: a home-base management phase and an overworld expedition phase, repeating indefinitely.

- Phase 1 — The Home Base: the player tends and automates a persistent base. Early on, resources are gathered by hand (e.g. manually chopping down a tree); as the player builds machines, that labor becomes automated, generating resources on a timer without manual input. Resources — from both the base and overworld maps — are spent to make the player and, eventually, the player's Giants stronger.
- Phase 2 — The Overworld Run: the player selects a map from an overworld selection screen, each map offering its own specific reward resource. On entering, the player fights through waves until a timer expires, at which point that map's boss spawns and must be defeated to complete the run. Defeating a boss for the first time permanently unlocks it as a controllable Giant, added to the player's growing Giant roster (Section 5.4).

These two phases mirror Cult of the Lamb's cult-management-vs-crusade structure, but replace follower care with machine automation, and replace random crusade rewards with a boss-collecting Giant roster as the headline long-term goal. As before, there is no permadeath and no loss of earned resources between phases, which keeps the loop low-friction and lets meta-progression (Section 7.2) accumulate steadily — a good fit for a solo dev's need for a small number of systems that combine to create replayable depth.

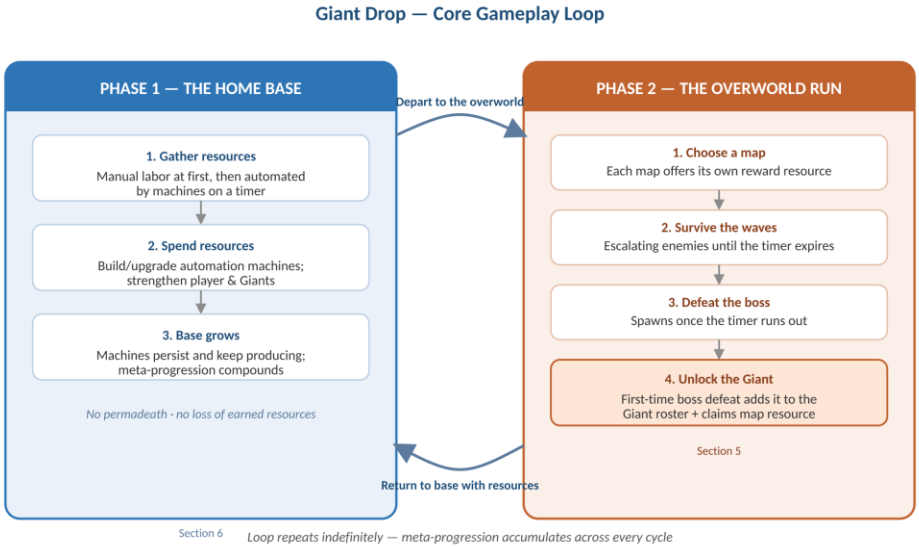


Figure 1 — the two-phase core gameplay loop: Phase 1 (Home Base) feeds resources into Phase 2 (Overworld Run), which feeds a growing Giant roster and map resources back into Phase 1.

5. Phase 2: The Overworld Run

5.1 Map Selection & Run Structure

Before a run, the player chooses a map from an overworld selection screen. Each map has its own specific reward resource, giving the player a reason to revisit different maps rather than grinding one repeatedly.

For now, this selection screen is scoped as a simple list, not an explorable overworld visual — a stack of named, selectable map entries (each with its own icon/theme callout) rather than a walkable map the player moves a cursor around on. This keeps the screen cheap to build and easy to extend as new maps unlock, deferring any

richer overworld visualization to later if it's ever wanted. See Section 14.1 for a reference (Ball x Pit) showing this list-of-regions style of selection screen.

Design note (draft — please review): A small handcrafted set of maps (2–3 to start) is the safer starting scope for a solo-dev MVP, each authored with a distinct theme, boss, and resource, rather than procedurally assembling maps from a pool of biomes/enemies. Procedural generation remains a possible later enhancement once the list-based selection screen and a handful of handcrafted maps prove the loop out.

Once inside a map, the structure is: survive escalating waves of enemies for a fixed timer (target 5–10 minutes, per the original survival-run pacing), then the map's boss spawns once that timer expires. The player must defeat the boss to complete the map and claim its rewards.

Design note (draft — please review): Confirm what happens if the player is overwhelmed before or during the boss fight — e.g. the run ends and returns the player to base, keeping whatever resources were gathered up to that point (consistent with the "no permanent loss" design), but without the boss-defeat reward or Giant unlock. This keeps stakes meaningful (the boss/Giant reward is genuinely at risk) without punishing the player by taking back earned resources.

5.2 Combat System

Combat is hybrid: some of the player's weapons auto-attack based on proximity/timers (Vampire Survivors style), while at least one weapon or ability is manually aimed and triggered, giving the player an active skill expression layer on top of the passive power fantasy.

- Auto-attack weapons: fire automatically at nearby enemies; the player's build comes from which weapons/passives are picked up and leveled during the run.
- Manual weapon/ability: aimed and fired directly by the player (twin-stick style), likely the highest-skill, highest-reward tool in the kit — a strong candidate for a weapon that also contributes to charging the Giant call-in meter faster (see 5.4).

Design note (draft — please review): Exact weapon list, leveling/evolution system, and pickup structure (level-up choice screen vs. automatic drops) are not yet defined — needed before combat implementation begins.

5.3 Enemy Waves & the Boss Fight

Enemies spawn in escalating swarms for the duration of the map's timer, consistent with the bullet-heaven genre: early waves are sparse and easy, later waves are dense and require the player's build (and, once unlocked, a Giant) to survive. Once the timer expires, wave-spawning ends and that map's boss enters the arena — a single, higher-stakes encounter capping off the run.

Design note (draft — please review): Enemy roster, wave/spawn-curve design, and the specific boss per map are not yet defined. Recommend defining a small starter bestiary (3–5 enemy types with distinct movement/attack patterns) plus one fully-designed boss before implementation, since this directly drives spawn-system, AI, and boss-encounter scope for the MVP.

5.4 The Giant System

The Giant is the game's signature mechanic, and it now works as a roster built through boss-collecting rather than a single generic power-up:

- Unlocking a Giant: the first time the player defeats a given map's boss, that boss is permanently added to the player's Giant roster — a one-time, per-boss unlock, not something re-earned every run.

- Loadout: before a run, the player equips one unlocked Giant from their roster to bring along (exact rules for equipping more than one are an open question — see Section 13).
- In-run trigger: once equipped, the call-in works via a cooldown meter that starts on a timer but is reduced faster the more enemies the player kills, rewarding aggressive play with earlier access to the Giant. This meter only runs while the player is in human form.
- Activation: calling in the Giant is a full character swap — the player's human character is replaced entirely by the equipped Giant for the duration; there is no simultaneous control of both.
- Duration: the Giant has its own health pool and remains active until destroyed (not a flat timer); the player has a limited number of call-ins available per run.
- End state: once the active Giant is destroyed, control reverts to the human character, and only then does the cooldown/kill-reduction meter for the next call-in begin building (if uses remain). Confirmed: the cooldown for the next Giant does not start while the current Giant is still alive on the map — it is destruction-gated, not running in parallel on a fixed schedule.

Design note (draft — please review): Needs explicit numbers before implementation: base cooldown duration, how much each kill reduces it, and uses-per-run. Also still open: whether each boss-derived Giant has a fully unique kit (movement/attacks/abilities) or shares a common Giant "chassis" with boss-specific skins/abilities layered on (the former is more thematically satisfying but scales dev cost with every new boss — a real scope risk for a solo dev and worth deciding deliberately), and whether the player can equip/bring more than one Giant per run.

6. Phase 1: The Home Base

6.1 Base Layout & Building

The base uses grid-based placement: buildings snap to a fixed grid, in the tradition of city-builders/colony sims. This keeps placement, saving/loading, and balancing straightforward for a solo dev, and pairs naturally with a top-down/isometric camera (Section 9).

Base building in Giant Drop is explicitly modeled on Cult of the Lamb's base-tending loop, but with machines standing in for followers: instead of assigning and caring for followers, the player builds and places automation machines. There is no crew/survivor management, no research tree separate from the machines themselves, and no crafting subsystem — those were explicitly ruled out to keep scope solo-dev-sized.

6.2 Automation Machines

The intended progression within the base is: the player starts by gathering a resource manually (e.g. chopping down a tree by hand, Cult of the Lamb style), then unlocks a machine that performs that same task automatically on a timer — producing a fixed amount of resource every fixed interval (x amount of time → x amount of resource) without further manual input. This turns early hands-on busywork into a satisfying automation goal, and gives the base a visible sense of growth as more of it runs itself. See Section 14.2 for a visual reference (PlateUp!) showing manual and automated stations living side by side in the same top-down space.

Design note (draft — please review): This automation timer is confirmed to run independently of Phase 2 (it is "not related to Phase 2") — machines produce on their own schedule regardless of what the player is doing. What's still open is whether that timer only ticks while the game is actively running (in either phase, or only while the player is physically in the base) versus true idle-game-style production that continues even while the game is closed. Recommend starting with "ticks in real time whenever the game session is running" for the MVP, since

offline/idle accounting adds real complexity (timestamp tracking, catch-up calculations) that isn't needed to prove the loop.

Below is a minimal starter proposal for early machines, sized to prove out the grid-building and automation systems — treat this as a placeholder to edit, not a locked list.

Machine	Manual Version (early game)	Automated Version (unlocked later)
Gatherer	Player manually harvests a base resource (e.g. chopping a tree) with a direct action.	Machine harvests the same resource automatically every fixed interval, no input needed.
Refinery	Player manually converts raw resources into a spendable currency.	Machine converts stockpiled raw resources into currency automatically over time.
Forge / Armory	Player manually crafts or equips gear from resources.	N/A — remains a manual spend-resources-for-upgrade station (see 6.4).
Giant Bay	N/A — thematic home for the Giant roster/loadout screen.	Passive bonus once built: e.g. reduces base Giant cooldown or adds an extra call-in use per run.

Design note (draft — please review): This list is a placeholder to validate the systems (grid + manual-to-automated resource loop + upgrade spend), not a final content plan. Expect it to change once the setting (Section 3), map resources (6.3), and boss/Giant roster (5.4) are locked, since those will suggest more specific, thematically grounded machines.

6.3 Resource Economy

There are now two resource tracks, mirroring the two phases:

- Base resources: gathered manually at first, then via automation machines (Section 6.2), used to build and upgrade machines and base structures.
- Map resources: each overworld map (Section 5.1) has its own specific reward resource, earned by completing that map, used to strengthen the player and/or unlock or upgrade Giants.

Design note (draft — please review): Exact resource identities for both tracks are not yet defined. A sci-fi-meets-fantasy setting suggests a natural split (e.g. a "tech/scrap" base resource vs. "essence"-type map resources tied to each boss's theme), but this is a proposal, not a decision. Also open: whether map resources are used only for player/Giant strengthening (6.4) or also feed back into base building, the way Cult of the Lamb's crusade resources sometimes gate cult-side content.

6.4 Strengthening the Player & Giants

Both base resources and map resources ultimately feed into making the player and their Giants stronger — this is the throughline connecting Phase 1 and Phase 2. The exact upgrade system (a stat-upgrade menu, a skill tree, per-Giant upgrade paths, or some combination) is not yet defined.

Design note (draft — please review): Define: what the player spends resources on (a shared upgrade tree vs. separate player and per-Giant trees), whether upgrades are purely stat-based (damage, health) or unlock new abilities, and which resource track pays for which upgrades. This is a prerequisite for both the base UI and the run HUD, and is one of the more consequential remaining design gaps.

7. Progression Systems

7.1 In-Run Progression

Within a single overworld run, the player levels up their character/weapons (typical of the genre — exact leveling curve TBD per Section 5.2) and builds toward the Giant call-in via the kill-reduced cooldown (Section 5.4). None of this in-run progress persists once the run ends; it resets each run by design, which is standard for the genre and keeps runs replayable.

7.2 Meta-Progression (Cross-Run)

Meta-progression is entirely additive — nothing built or unlocked is ever lost — and now comes from three confirmed sources:

- Automation growth: machines built in the base persist and keep producing resources over time, so the base's resource output compounds the more the player invests (Section 6.2).
- Player & Giant strengthening: base and map resources are spent on permanent upgrades to the player character and to individual Giants (Section 6.4).
- Giant roster growth: defeating a new boss for the first time permanently adds it to the player's Giant roster — the headline long-term collection goal of the game (Section 5.4).

The base itself also persists and visibly grows machine-by-machine, giving the player a tangible sense of long-term progress independent of any single run's outcome, while the Giant roster gives them a clear “what's next” goal (which boss haven't I beaten yet) at any point in the game.

8. Player Character

For the initial release, there is a single fixed player character — all build variety comes from weapon and item choices during a run (Section 5.2) and permanent bonuses from the base (Section 7.2), not from character selection.

Design note (draft — please review): Multiple selectable characters/classes are explicitly a later consideration, not part of the first-release scope. When revisited, the Armory/unlock system in Section 6–7 is the natural place to hang new characters.

Character identity (name, appearance, backstory/why they're the one calling in the Giant) is not yet defined and is tied to the setting work in Section 3.

9. Art & Audio Direction

9.1 Visual Style

3D, viewed from a top-down/isometric camera, rendered with a heavy cel-shading treatment: bold black ink outlines, flat/graphic shading steps rather than smooth gradients, and a moody, painterly comic-book palette — closer to Hellboy or the Mecha Legends demo trailer (reference below) than a clean flat-shaded mobile-game look. Skies and backgrounds lean toward inked, textured cloud/linework detail; foreground characters, Giants, and effects (muzzle flares, tech glow) pop with saturated accent color against a desaturated world.



Mecha Legends — New Demo Trailer (Animanicks). Reference for the target rendering treatment: heavy cel-shading, thick ink outlines, comic-panel linework on the environment, saturated highlight colors (jet flare, creature) against a desaturated moody backdrop. Source: user-provided screenshot, YouTube.

Design note (draft — please review): This is a heavier art lift than a plain low-poly/flat-shaded look: convincing cel-shading needs a custom toon shader plus an outline post-process (rim-light or inverted-hull outlines), and most off-the-shelf low-poly asset-store packs are not textured/lit for this look out of the box — they'll likely need re-shading or re-texturing rather than dropping in as-is. Recommend an early shader R&D spike (get one hero asset — e.g. the player character or first Giant — looking right end-to-end) before committing the asset pipeline, since this choice affects whether purchased low-poly packs remain viable placeholders per Section 9.2's plan.

9.2 Asset Production Plan

Mixed approach: placeholder or purchased low-poly assets are used first to build and test gameplay systems; custom art (hand-made or heavily modified from purchased bases) replaces placeholders closer to release once the core loop is proven. This sequencing avoids sinking solo-dev art time into systems that might still change.

9.3 Audio

Design note (draft — please review): Not yet discussed. Recommend a follow-up pass covering: music direction (tense/ambient during runs vs. calmer at base), SFX priorities (Giant call-in should be a signature audio moment), and whether audio is sourced (asset packs/library music) or custom, matching the art plan's placeholder-then-custom approach.

10. Technical Overview

10.1 Engine & Target Specs

Unity is the target engine per project setup. Recommend pinning a specific Unity LTS version at project creation and documenting minimum/recommended PC specs once a vertical slice exists to benchmark against (swarm combat with many enemies on screen is the likely performance bottleneck to watch).

10.2 Architecture Considerations

- Object pooling is essential given large numbers of enemies/projectiles on screen simultaneously (standard requirement for the bullet-heaven genre).
- A clean separation between run-state (resets every run) and base/meta-state (persists across runs) should be established early, since nearly every system in this document reads or writes one or the other.

- Save/load only needs to persist base-state (structures built, unlocks, permanent bonuses) — no mid-run save/resume is implied by the current design (short runs, no loss on exit).
- Each Giant is effectively its own playable character/controller that swaps in for the human character — plan the player-controller architecture around a base Giant-controller class other bosses can extend, rather than one-off code per Giant, to keep the roster scalable for a solo dev.
- Automation machines need a lightweight production-tick system (each machine tracks its own interval/output) that runs independently of which phase the player is in (Section 6.2) — a simple per-machine timer component is likely sufficient for the MVP; avoid building full offline/idle-accounting infrastructure until it's confirmed as needed.

Design note (draft — please review): This section will expand significantly once Section 13's open questions are resolved and a vertical slice defines real performance/content targets.

11. Scope, Milestones & MVP Definition

Recommended for a solo developer: build the smallest possible vertical slice that proves the full core loop (Section 4) end-to-end before expanding content. Proposed milestone breakdown:

Milestone	Goal	Key Deliverables
M0 — Foundations	Project setup, architecture, placeholder art pipeline.	Unity project scaffold, base-state/run-state separation, basic player movement + camera (both phases).
M1 — Combat Prototype	Prove the hybrid combat feel.	1 auto-attack weapon, 1 manual weapon, 1–2 enemy types, wave-spawn-on-timer system, object pooling.
M2 — Boss & Giant Prototype	Prove the signature mechanic end-to-end.	1 fully-designed boss, boss-defeat → Giant-unlock flow, kill-reduced cooldown meter, character-swap to Giant, Giant health/combat, destroy-and-revert flow.
M3 — Base Prototype	Prove the automation meta-loop.	Grid placement, 1 manual-gather resource + its automated machine, resource economy (base + map tracks), save/load of base-state.
M4 — Vertical Slice	Full loop, playable end-to-end.	Map select → run → boss → base → run loop with real (if placeholder-art) content, first balance pass on player/Giant strengthening.
M5+ — Content & Polish	Expand roster, art, audio, UI/UX.	Additional maps/bosses/Giants, full machine/weapon rosters, custom art pass, audio pass, Steam page prep.

This milestone plan is a proposal to be refined once Section 13's open questions are resolved — it's included here so the document can drive a concrete Unity task breakdown (the next step of this process).

12. Release & Monetization Plan

Not yet decided. Two common paths worth deciding between once a vertical slice exists: a premium (paid, one-time-purchase) release aimed at a fuller scope before launch, or a Steam Early Access release to get the core loop in front of players sooner and expand content post-launch with community feedback. No decision blocks early development — this can be revisited around the M4 vertical-slice milestone.

13. Open Design Questions / Risks

Consolidated list of every gap flagged elsewhere in this document. Resolving these — even provisionally — before the Unity task breakdown will make that breakdown far more concrete.

- Setting fiction: what is the sci-fi setting specifically, and why do fantasy creatures exist within it? (Section 3)
- How each boss's identity bridges sci-fi and fantasy, and how that identity carries over into its Giant form. (Section 3, 5.4)
- Overworld map structure: the selection screen is now scoped as a simple list (Section 5.1, ref. 14.1) rather than an explorable visual overworld, but handcrafted vs. procedural map content and how many maps/bosses are needed for the MVP are still open. (Section 5.1)
- What happens if the player is overwhelmed before/during a boss fight — run-ends-and-returns-to-base is proposed, needs confirmation. (Section 5.1)
- Weapon list, leveling/evolution system, and pickup structure. (Section 5.2)
- Starter enemy bestiary and wave/spawn-curve design. (Section 5.3)
- First boss design (the one needed for the M2 milestone) — kit, arena, defeat conditions. (Section 5.3)
- Giant numbers: cooldown duration, per-kill reduction amount, uses-per-run; whether each Giant has a fully unique kit or shares a common chassis with per-boss skins/abilities (a real scope decision for a solo dev); whether more than one Giant can be equipped per run. (Section 5.4)
- Whether the base's production timer ticks only while the game is running, or also while it's closed (true idle/offline generation). (Section 6.2)
- Final machine list, once setting and resources are locked. (Section 6.2)
- Resource identities/theme for both the base and map tracks, and exactly what each gates. (Section 6.3)
- The player/Giant upgrade system itself — shared tree vs. per-Giant trees, stat-only vs. new abilities, and which resource track pays for what. (Section 6.4)
- Cel-shading feasibility: the target look (Section 9.1) needs a custom toon shader plus outline post-process, and most low-poly asset-store packs won't already look right under it — needs an early shader R&D pass on one hero asset before locking the asset pipeline. (Section 9.1, 9.2)
- Audio direction. (Section 9.3)
- Unity LTS version and target hardware specs. (Section 10.1)
- Release format (premium vs. Early Access). (Section 12)

14. Visual References

These are official screenshots (captured from each game's Steam store page) for the games whose systems Giant Drop draws on most closely — a mood-board starting point, not a copy target. Full galleries are linked below each image for more.

14.1 Map Selection — Ball x Pit

The screenshot below is the reference for Section 5.1's list-based map selection: a stack of named, selectable regions (“The Bone Yard”, “The Snowy Shores”, “The Liminal Desert”), each with its own icon and visual theme, but no explorable overworld the player walks a cursor around on. This is the target shape for Giant Drop's map selection screen for now — simple, list-like, easy to extend with new maps.



Ball x Pit — region/map selection screen. Source: user-provided screenshot.

Full screenshot gallery: steamcommunity.com/app/2062430/screenshots

14.2 Automation — PlateUp!

The kitchen shot below shows PlateUp!'s core hook: manual stations (chopping, plating) sitting right next to automated ones (the “Auto Pizza” station bottom-left, conveyor-style counters, self-serving dispensers) in the same top-down space, with customers flowing through as the throughput test. That's the clearest existing reference for Section 6.2's manual-to-automated progression — the automated version of a task should visibly replace the manual one in the same physical spot on the grid, not live in a separate menu.



PlateUp! — kitchen with manual and automated stations side by side. Source: Steam store page screenshot gallery, store.steampowered.com/app/1599600/PlateUp

Full screenshot gallery: steamcommunity.com/app/1599600/screenshots

14.3 Base Automation — Cult of the Lamb

The base-overview shot below: a grid of buildings and shrines with followers moving between them, resource counters along the top of the screen. That's the closest existing visual analogue to Phase 1's overall base layout — swap “followers” for “automation machines” and it's a close match for the grid-based, top-down base described in Section 6.



Cult of the Lamb — base overview. Source: Steam store page screenshot gallery, store.steampowered.com/app/1313140/Cult_of_the_Lamb

Full screenshot gallery: steamcommunity.com/app/1313140/screenshots

14.4 Swarm Combat — Vampire Survivors

The mid-run shot below: the player character nearly buried under a dense crowd of enemies, screen filled with auto-fired projectile trails and on-screen damage numbers. That's the visual benchmark for Phase 2's escalating waves described in Section 5.3 — sparse and readable early, overwhelming and chaotic by the time the boss timer expires.



Vampire Survivors — mid-run swarm. Source: Steam store page screenshot gallery, store.steampowered.com/app/1794680/Vampire_Survivors

Full screenshot gallery: steamcommunity.com/app/1794680/screenshots

14.5 The Giant Call-In — Titanfall 2

The shot below shows two Titans at full scale, squared off — the closest official screenshot found to Giant Drop's Giant-scale combat. For the specific call-in/embark beat (a Pilot calling in a Titan and climbing into it, HUD switching from human-scale to Titan-scale), the “Become One” cinematic moment is worth studying directly via the gallery link below — it wasn't captured as a static store screenshot.



Titanfall 2 — Titan vs. Titan. Source: Steam store page screenshot gallery, store.steampowered.com/app/1237970/Titanfall_2

Full screenshot gallery: steamcommunity.com/app/1237970/screenshots

15. Glossary

Term	Definition
Phase 1 / Home Base	The base-management phase between runs: automate resource gathering with machines and spend resources to strengthen the player and Giants.
Phase 2 / Overworld Run	The expedition phase: choose a map, survive waves until the timer expires, then defeat that map's boss.
Map	A selectable overworld destination with its own enemies, boss, and specific reward resource.
Boss	The single enemy that spawns once a map's survival timer expires; must be defeated to complete the map.
The Giant / Giant Roster	A boss the player has defeated at least once, permanently unlocked as a controllable war machine/creature the player can equip and call in on future runs — replacing their human character until it's destroyed.
Machine	A base building that automates a previously-manual resource-gathering task, producing a fixed amount of resource on a fixed timer.
Base resources	Resources gathered (manually, then via machines) in the Home Base phase; spent on machines and base upgrades.
Map resources	Resources earned by completing a specific overworld map; spent on strengthening the player and Giants.
Meta-progression	Any progress that persists across runs — machines built, player/Giant upgrades purchased, and the Giant roster.
In-run progression	Temporary power gained during a single run (levels, weapon pickups) that resets when the run ends.